

DSAT Reading & Writing — Main Purpose — SOLUTIONS

25 Original Practice Questions | Easy · Medium · Hard

Q1. [Easy]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The passage describes the waggle dance mechanism—angle indicates direction, duration indicates distance—and how other bees use this information. The purpose is to explain this communicative behavior.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) The passage does not compare honeybee intelligence with other species.
- C) No other insect species' communication is mentioned.
- D) The passage does not discuss the honeybee life cycle.

TRAP ALERT: Option B infers a judgment ('more intelligent') that the passage never makes. Purpose questions ask what the author **DOES**, not what you can infer.

KEY INSIGHT: Main Purpose = what the author is **DOING** (explaining, arguing, comparing, describing).
Main Idea = what the text **SAYS**.

FAST METHOD: The passage is purely explanatory—no argument, no comparison. Only B describes an explanatory purpose.

Q2. [Easy]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The passage shows a grandfather teaching his grandson to mend nets and offering the lesson 'The net does not care how fast you work. It cares that you finish.' The purpose is to depict this generational teaching moment.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) Economic hardship is not discussed in the passage.
- B) The tone is gentle, not critical. The grandfather says 'Patience,' not a rebuke.
- C) Modern technology is not mentioned.

TRAP ALERT: Option B misreads the grandfather's tone. 'Patience' is instruction, not criticism.

KEY INSIGHT: In literary passages, the purpose often involves character dynamics (teaching, revealing, contrasting).

FAST METHOD: What is the passage **DOING**? Showing a lesson being passed down. That matches A.

Q3. [Easy]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The passage reports the results of removing fines (more cardholders, better return rates) and the rationale (fines discourage low-income users). The purpose is to present both outcomes and reasoning.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The passage reports on one library's program; it does not prescribe a universal policy.
- C) The history of public libraries is not discussed.
- D) Rural libraries are not mentioned.

TRAP ALERT: Option A overgeneralizes from one example to a universal prescription. The passage presents, not prescribes.

KEY INSIGHT: Purpose answers that use 'all' or prescriptive language ('should') are usually wrong unless the passage explicitly argues for a universal position.

FAST METHOD: The passage has two parts: results + rationale. Only A mentions both.

Q4. [Easy]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The passage describes the Silk Road as facilitating trade AND cultural exchange (ideas, religions, technologies). The purpose is to show both dimensions.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) 'A single religion' is too narrow; the passage mentions religions generally.
- C) The passage does not discuss why the Silk Road declined.
- D) Modern shipping is not mentioned.

TRAP ALERT: Option A narrows 'religions' (plural) to 'a single religion.' Watch for scope reductions in wrong answers.

KEY INSIGHT: When a passage covers multiple aspects of a topic, the correct purpose answer should be broad enough to encompass all of them.

FAST METHOD: Key words: 'goods' + 'ideas, religions, technologies.' The answer must cover both commercial and cultural exchange.

Q5. [Easy]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The passage explains how the trap works (hinged leaves, trigger hairs, snap shut) and why it requires two stimulations (to prevent false alarms). Both mechanism and reason are described.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) No other carnivorous plants are mentioned.
- B) Endangerment is not discussed.
- C) Venus flytraps are not classified as animals; this contradicts basic biology.

TRAP ALERT: Option C introduces a bizarre claim (classifying plants as animals). Always eliminate factually absurd options quickly.

KEY INSIGHT: Purpose answers should describe what the passage actually covers—mechanism + rationale here.

FAST METHOD: Two elements: how the trap works + why it needs two touches. Only A covers both.

Q6. [Easy]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Elder Nkechi's comment reveals that choosing the levee 40 years ago created an ongoing repair burden. The purpose is to show her observation about the consequences of a past decision.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The passage does not celebrate the council's response; Nkechi's tone is reflective, possibly critical.
- B) The passage does not take a position on levees vs. relocation as a general matter.
- C) Engineering techniques are not described.

TRAP ALERT: Option B turns a specific observation into a universal rule ('always preferable'). The passage is narrating, not prescribing.

KEY INSIGHT: Literary purpose questions often hinge on tone. Nkechi's tone is wry/reflective, not celebratory.

FAST METHOD: Nkechi's quote implies irony: 'we have been repairing it ever since.' This is observation of a recurring burden → D.

Q7. [Easy]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The passage presents Vasquez's finding (higher revenue in walkable areas) and her explanation (more pedestrian traffic → more impulse visits). Option A captures both the finding and its proposed cause.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) 'Demolished and rebuilt' is far more extreme than anything the passage suggests.
- C) The passage compares neighborhoods, not business sizes.
- D) The passage does not describe measurement methods.

TRAP ALERT: Option B introduces a radical policy recommendation the passage never makes.

KEY INSIGHT: Finding + explanation = common two-part purpose structure in social science passages.

FAST METHOD: Pattern: researcher found X because of Y. The answer must include both X and Y.

Q8. [Medium]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The passage introduces cryptochrome (a specific protein), describes Petrov's experiment (disrupting it impaired magnetic orientation), and notes that other navigational cues were unaffected. The purpose is to present evidence linking the protein to magnetic navigation.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The passage does not rank navigational cues by importance.
- C) Migratory routes are not compared between species.
- D) Population decline is not discussed.

TRAP ALERT: Option A overstates: the passage shows cryptochrome is involved in magnetic sensing but does not claim birds rely on magnetism 'more than any other cue.'

KEY INSIGHT: Distinguish 'involved in' from 'most important.' The passage proves a link, not a hierarchy.

FAST METHOD: The passage is about one protein and one experiment. Only A is specific enough.

Q9. [Medium]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The passage traces the trajectory: overlooked work → Yellin's verification and critical edition → restored scholarly attention → demonstrated significance. The purpose is to show how Yellin's work rescued the autobiography.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) The passage does not rank the autobiography against other works.
- C) Escape techniques are not discussed.
- D) The passage explains Yellin's contribution without criticizing earlier scholars.

TRAP ALERT: Option D introduces a critical tone ('criticize scholars who failed') that the passage does not adopt. The passage is descriptive, not accusatory.

KEY INSIGHT: The purpose is what the author does with the information. Describing ≠ criticizing.

FAST METHOD: Action verbs: 'spent years verifying,' 'restored to scholarly attention,' 'revealed complexity.' This is rescue + demonstration → A.

Q10. [Medium]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The passage describes fire's ecological benefits, then pivots (via 'however') to Moreno's warning about excessively frequent fires causing permanent shifts. The purpose is to present both sides: benefit and risk.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) 'Complete suppression' is not advocated; the passage acknowledges fire's benefits.
- B) Chemical processes are briefly mentioned but are not the passage's focus.
- D) Boreal forests are not mentioned.

TRAP ALERT: Option A takes Moreno's concern about frequency and converts it into an argument for total suppression—a leap the passage never makes.

KEY INSIGHT: When a passage says 'X is beneficial, but too much X is harmful,' the purpose covers both halves.

FAST METHOD: Pivot at 'however' → the purpose spans both sides. Only A does this.

Q11. [Medium]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The poem uses shells accumulating on a windowsill as a metaphor for time passing. The decision about whether to 'make room for more or accept that the collection was finished' represents the limits of accumulation.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The text is a poem, not a scientific account.
- B) No shop or commercial activity is mentioned.
- D) The poem does not argue for or against clock-watching; it simply uses an alternative measure.

TRAP ALERT: Option D introduces an argument ('should spend more/less time') that the poem never makes. Poetry often observes without prescribing.

KEY INSIGHT: In poetry, the purpose often involves using imagery as metaphor. Identify what the image represents.

FAST METHOD: Shells = passage of time. 'Whether to make room or accept' = limits of accumulation → C.

Q12. [Medium]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The passage presents data (89% vs. 55% turnout) and then qualifies the finding: high turnout does not equal civic engagement (blank/spoiled ballots). The purpose is to present both the finding and its limitation.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The passage does not advocate for universal adoption of compulsory voting.
- B) The history of compulsory voting is not discussed.
- D) The passage does not conclude that voluntary systems produce better outcomes.

TRAP ALERT: Option A converts a nuanced presentation into a one-sided argument. The passage's 'however' signals balance.

KEY INSIGHT: When a passage presents data and then qualifies it, the purpose must include both elements.

FAST METHOD: Two-part pattern: finding (higher turnout) + caveat (not necessarily more engagement). Only A has both.

Q13. [Medium]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The passage describes disease threatening the canal, Gorgas's mosquito-control campaign, reduced deaths, and the project's completion. The purpose is to show how a health intervention enabled an engineering achievement.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The passage does not argue against the canal's construction.
- B) Terrain challenges are not the passage's subject.
- D) Modern construction practices are not mentioned.

TRAP ALERT: Option A introduces a moral judgment ('should not have been built') that the passage does not express.

KEY INSIGHT: History passages often show cause-and-effect: intervention → outcome. The purpose captures this link.

FAST METHOD: Key chain: disease threatened project → Gorgas intervened → project succeeded. That is A.

Q14. [Medium]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The passage introduces Rossi's hypothesis (three factors explain deep-sea gigantism in isopods) and then notes her acknowledgment that the explanation may be incomplete. The purpose includes both the hypothesis and its limitation.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) 'Exclusively by low predation pressure' ignores the other two factors Rossi mentions.
- C) Diet is not discussed in detail.
- D) The passage does not compare all crustacean body sizes.

TRAP ALERT: Option B cherry-picks one of three proposed factors and presents it as the sole cause. This is a common distortion in wrong answers.

KEY INSIGHT: When a researcher proposes multiple factors, the correct answer should not reduce them to one.

FAST METHOD: Hypothesis + 'acknowledges... may not fully explain' → the answer must include both. That is A.

Q15. [Medium]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Augusto's view evolves: he once equated silence with consent but comes to see it as endurance under oppression. The purpose is to convey this shift in understanding.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) Economic conditions are not the passage's subject, though economic metaphor ('currency') is used.
- C) The passage does not make a moral argument about silence being acceptable.
- D) No other characters are described or contrasted.

TRAP ALERT: Option B confuses figurative language ('currency') with literal economic content. Read metaphors as metaphors.

KEY INSIGHT: When a character's perspective changes within the passage, the purpose is usually to convey that evolution.

FAST METHOD: Key transition: 'had always believed... began to suspect it was something else.'
Evolution → A.

Q16. [Medium]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The passage presents Yamamoto's finding that giver status matters more than gift value and her argument that this reinforces social hierarchies. The purpose is to report this research finding.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The passage describes practices without criticizing the communities.
- B) Types of gifts are not the focus; the social dynamics of exchange are.
- C) The passage does not discuss the decline of gift exchange in modern societies.

TRAP ALERT: Option A adds a normative judgment ('criticize') that the passage's neutral, descriptive tone does not support.

KEY INSIGHT: Research-based passages typically have the purpose of 'presenting findings,' not 'criticizing subjects.'

FAST METHOD: The passage is neutral and descriptive. Eliminate answers with judgmental verbs ('criticize,' 'argue against').

Q17. [Medium]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The passage introduces the Mpemba effect (a puzzle), presents Borg's proposed explanation (hydrogen-bond changes), and notes that experimental confirmation is difficult. The purpose spans all three elements.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) 'Definitively explained' contradicts 'experimental confirmation has proven difficult.'
- C) The passage does not compare theories about water's molecular structure.
- D) Industrial applications are not discussed.

TRAP ALERT: Option A overstates the status of Borg's work. The passage uses qualifying language ('proposed,' 'proven difficult').

KEY INSIGHT: When a passage uses hedging language, the correct purpose answer should hedge similarly.

FAST METHOD: Three-part structure: puzzle + proposed answer + challenge. Only A covers all three.

Q18. [Hard]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The passage describes anomalous stellar events, notes their partial similarity to supernovae, presents Chandrasekaran's hypothesis, and acknowledges that instrumental artifacts have not been ruled out. The purpose is to describe new observations while flagging uncertainty.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) 'Refute... definitive evidence' is too strong; the passage says artifacts have not been ruled out.
- C) Spectroscopic techniques are mentioned briefly but are not the passage's focus.
- D) 'All low-mass stars' contradicts the passage, which discusses only 'a class of anomalous transient events.'

TRAP ALERT: Option A converts an uncertain hypothesis into definitive refutation. Match the passage's epistemic caution.

KEY INSIGHT: Hard purpose questions test whether you can distinguish tentative description from definitive argumentation.

FAST METHOD: 'Have not been conclusively ruled out' = uncertainty. Only A reflects this.

Q19. [Hard]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Al-Rashid reveals that bimaristans had systematic medical practices (patient records, drug trials, specialized wards) and argues for fuller recognition. The purpose is to present her case for upgrading their historical status.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) Al-Rashid explicitly says she does NOT claim bimaristans were modern hospitals.
- C) 'Deliberately suppressing' implies malice the passage does not attribute to Western scholars.
- D) Architecture is not discussed.

TRAP ALERT: Option B contradicts the passage's own caveat ('does not claim that bimaristans were modern hospitals in disguise').

KEY INSIGHT: When a passage explicitly disavows a claim, any answer that makes that claim is wrong.

FAST METHOD: The passage says 'does not claim X; rather, argues Y.' The answer must be about Y, not X.

Q20. [Hard]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Ishikawa's fMRI studies show both hemispheres are active during creative and analytical tasks, challenging the left/right dichotomy. The purpose is to present evidence against a popular oversimplification.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) Ishikawa connects neuroscience TO education (warning against misleading curricula), not away from it.
- B) fMRI development is not the passage's topic.
- D) The passage does not compare Ishikawa's findings with supporters of the dichotomy.

TRAP ALERT: Option A reverses Ishikawa's point: she argues neuroscience IS relevant to education (hence the concern about misleading curricula).

KEY INSIGHT: Read carefully for direction: Ishikawa says the dichotomy 'may lead educators to design curricula around a misleading model'—she cares about education, not dismissing it.

FAST METHOD: Core action: challenging a popular dichotomy with evidence. That is A.

Q21. [Hard]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The speaker expected grief to arrive 'all at once, like a wave' but found it came 'in installments.' The purpose is to describe this gradual, incremental nature of grief.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) 'Universal... everyone identically' is far too broad for a personal essay.
- B) The passage describes experience, not advice.
- C) No other family members are mentioned.

TRAP ALERT: Option B confuses memoir (personal narrative) with self-help (practical advice). The passage reflects; it does not prescribe.

KEY INSIGHT: Personal essays usually have the purpose of conveying experience or insight, not giving advice.

FAST METHOD: The contrast is: expected (wave) vs. actual (installments). Purpose = describing that difference → D.

Q22. [Hard]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The passage introduces the standard model's limitation (cannot explain high-temperature superconductors), presents Kessler's alternative (magnetic fluctuations), notes its successes, and flags its own unresolved challenges (nickel-oxide anomalies). The purpose spans this full arc.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) 'Abandoned entirely' overstates; the passage positions Kessler's model as an alternative, not a total replacement.
- C) Industrial applications are not discussed.
- D) The passage does not compare nickel-oxide and copper-oxide for manufacturing superiority.

TRAP ALERT: Option A uses absolute language ('abandoned entirely'). The passage says Kessler's model addresses certain limitations, not that the standard model is worthless.

KEY INSIGHT: In science passages with competing models, the purpose is usually to present the new model and its status, not to declare total victory over the old one.

FAST METHOD: Three elements: limitation of old model → new model → new model's own gaps. Only A captures all three.

Q23. [Hard]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Malhotra argues that Mohenjo-daro's uniformity implies centralized planning but cautions against equating centralization with autocracy, noting the absence of palatial structures. The purpose is to present this nuanced argument.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) Egyptian cities are not mentioned.
- B) Malhotra explicitly cautions against assuming autocracy (rule by a single king).
- D) Dating methods are not discussed.

TRAP ALERT: Option B directly contradicts Malhotra's caveat. She distinguishes centralization from kingship.

KEY INSIGHT: When an archaeologist makes a claim and then explicitly limits it, the purpose must include the limitation.

FAST METHOD: Malhotra says centralized ≠ autocratic. Only A captures both the argument and the distinction.

Q24. [Hard]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Asante argues that merit is entangled with structural advantages, and treating outcomes as purely merit-based can justify inequality. The purpose is to present this critique.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) Asante 'does not deny that talent and effort matter'—he challenges the purity of meritocratic claims, not the role of individual qualities entirely.
- C) The passage does not trace the term's history across cultures.
- D) Classical economists are not mentioned.

TRAP ALERT: Option B overstates: Asante nuances the role of merit rather than denying it entirely. Watch for the difference between 'X is insufficient' and 'X does not exist.'

KEY INSIGHT: Hard purpose questions often involve a thinker who qualifies, not eliminates, a concept. The correct answer must reflect that qualification.

FAST METHOD: Passage says 'does not deny that talent and effort matter; rather, he contends...' Purpose = presenting the qualified critique → A.

Q25. [Hard]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The botanist catalogs all species equally, argues that 'significance was not the same as visibility,' and believes the forest is held together by unseen organisms. The purpose is to convey his belief in the ecological importance of overlooked life forms.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The passage uses the botanist's work to make a thematic point, not to describe a daily routine.
- B) The passage does not argue for textbook changes; the botanist's point is philosophical, not curricular.
- C) The passage mentions colleagues teasing him but does not criticize them; it uses their reaction as contrast.

TRAP ALERT: Option C shifts the focus from the botanist's belief to criticism of colleagues. The colleagues are a foil, not the subject.

KEY INSIGHT: In literary passages, secondary characters often exist to highlight the protagonist's perspective, not to be the focus of the purpose.

FAST METHOD: The botanist's thesis: 'significance was not the same as visibility.' Purpose = conveying that belief → D.

TOPIC SUMMARY

Top 3 Mistakes:

- Confusing the passage's purpose (what the author DOES) with its main idea (what the text SAYS).
- Choosing an answer that describes only part of the passage's purpose (e.g., only the finding but not the caveat).
- Selecting an overly extreme purpose ('argue that all X should Y') when the passage is descriptive or balanced.

Top 3 Rules:

- Purpose = author's action (explain, compare, argue, present, illustrate, describe). Use action verbs to match.
- If the passage has a pivot ('however,' 'but'), the purpose should span both sides of the pivot.
- Eliminate answers that attribute a more extreme or narrow purpose than the passage supports.

Expected Frequency per Module: 2–4 Main Purpose questions per module (appears in both Module 1 and Module 2).